

1/5/26

Good evening. My name is Monica Strauser, and I am a resident of Kennett Township.

I would like to start by welcoming our new Supervisor, Mr. Bailey. We look forward to working with you as you serve Kennett Township.

I spoke at the December 3rd meeting, and I am here again tonight to **restate my opposition to the proposed municipal expansion and the associated tax increase schedule**, which the Board has now made clear is expected to total **roughly 20% over the next seven years**.

Petition and Community Sentiment

On December 1st, I started a petition on Change.org titled *“No New Taxes – Stop Municipal Expansion.”*

As of today, it has received over 430 signatures, all from concerned residents of this township.

That level of response should be taken seriously. It reflects what was also evident at the December 3rd meeting: **residents are not on board with this plan**.

The concerns are not ideological. They are practical:

- the **cost**,
- the **tax increases**, and
- the **mismatch between what’s being proposed and what our township actually needs**.

Tax Increases Despite a Growing Tax Base

The Board has repeatedly justified these tax increases by saying we need to “start ramping up” to pay for a new municipal building.

That reasoning does not hold up when you look at what is happening in Kennett Township.

Our township is **growing**:

- **Rosedale**: 72 new homes
- **Parkside**: 7 single-family homes, 76 townhomes, 100 apartments, plus retail

- **Kennett Pointe:** 53 townhomes, 24 apartments, and over 16,000 square feet of retail space

That is **hundreds of new residential units and significant new commercial development.**

More homes mean more taxpayers.

More businesses mean more revenue.

Growth in the tax base should be helping absorb administrative costs — not being used to justify aggressive, multi-year tax increases on existing residents.

Yet the Board has openly stated that the 20% increase over seven years is **only for the municipal building**, and that *any other township needs will require additional increases on top of that.*

That is deeply concerning.

Police Facility vs. Actual Police Work

I want to address the proposed police facility specifically.

The township's own **2025 KTPD Stats presentation** makes something very clear:

Kennett Township is a **low-crime community.**

The data shows that our police department largely functions as a **community response team:**

- non-criminal calls,
- welfare checks,
- traffic issues,
- quality-of-life concerns.

That is not a criticism — it is a strength of our community.

But it raises a fundamental question:

Why are we proposing a \$10 million, 11,000-square-foot, criminal-processing-oriented facility for a police force that spends most of its time responding to non-criminal matters?

The proposed building includes:

- holding cells,
- prisoner processing areas,
- a sally port,
- large evidence and interview spaces.

That design is **completely out of step** with the reality shown in the township's own statistics.

We also continue to rely on the **Pennsylvania State Police for overnight coverage**, which is entirely appropriate. That means we are talking about a **roughly 16-hour-a-day local force**, not a 24/7 operation.

So I have to ask — and many residents are asking the same thing:

Why does a low-crime township with partial State Police coverage need a \$10 million, city-style police station?

Scale, Cost, and Trust

This is not just about whether a new building would be “nice to have.”

It is about **scale, restraint, and trust**.

The cost is staggering.

The tax increases are long-term.

And the proposal feels disconnected from the actual needs of our community.

Residents are hearing assurances that “no final decision has been made,” while simultaneously being told that taxes must rise now to prepare for it. That contradiction undermines confidence.

Closing

I want to be very clear:

Residents are not saying “do nothing forever.”

We are saying:

- **Slow down**

- **Listen**
- **Right-size the solution**
- **Respect the growing tax base**
- **Do not lock residents into years of tax increases for a plan they do not support**

The message from the community is consistent, growing, and unmistakable:

This plan is too big, too expensive, and out of sync with the realities of Kennett Township.

I urge the Board — especially new members — to pause, reassess, and genuinely engage the community before moving any further down this path.

Thank you for your time.